

POU11011 — Discussion points and tutorials

The 10% component · Michaelmas Term 2026

Dr Noah Buckley

The short version

Weight	10% of the module mark
What you submit	Three numbered discussion points, at most one page
How many times	Three, across the term's four tutorials
When	The evening before the tutorial, by 20:00
Where	The Discussion Points folder on Blackboard
Marked	Pass/fail. Not graded on style
The catch	You must submit <i>and</i> attend. Either one alone earns nothing

Why this exists

Four tutorials is not many. If people turn up having skimmed the reading on the walk over, the session becomes me-by-proxy: your TA talks, twenty students nod. That is a waste of the one hour in this module where you get to argue with somebody.

So the deal is that you arrive having already written down what you want to argue about. Your TA reads the submissions beforehand and builds the session around them. The points are the agenda, not a hoop.

There is a second reason, and I will be straight about it: writing something about the reading a week after the lecture is the only thing in this module that makes you retrieve the material before December. Students who do this consistently do better on the essay. That is not a motivational line, it is what the marks look like.

What to write

Three numbered points. Each at most a paragraph. One page in total.

You are not being asked for a polished analysis, and there is no thesis statement to construct. You are being asked to raise something worth twenty minutes of argument.

Things that work:

- What is the argument actually claiming, and what would have to be true for it to hold?

- Where does the argument fit the cases badly? Name the case.
- Something in the news this month that the reading explains — or fails to.
- Do you believe it? What is the alternative explanation?
- Two readings that disagree, and what the disagreement turns on.

Things that do not work: a summary of the reading; three variations on “this was interesting”; a point that could have been written without opening the text.

Write it in whatever register you like. Nobody is marking your prose here.

The mechanics

Which tutorials. Discussion points attach to **tutorials 2, 3 and 4**. Tutorial 1 is orientation — how the module works, how to read a political science article, what your TA expects — and carries no submission. Attend it anyway; it is where the group is set up.

[DECISION for Noah — default applied: points attach to tutorials 2, 3 and 4, with tutorial 1 as orientation. The alternative is to let students choose any three of the four, which is friendlier but means tutorial 1 has no prepared room and tutorial 4 gets skipped by everyone who has banked three passes.]

Deadline: 20:00 the evening before your tutorial meets. Not the start of the tutorial. Your TA needs to read twenty of these and plan a session around them, and cannot do that at 9am.

[DECISION for Noah — default applied: 20:00 the evening before. Last year’s Intro said “before the tutorial”; Comparative A says “midnight before”. 20:00 is the version that actually gives the TA a working evening.]

Late points are not accepted. Not at 21:00, not on the morning of. The whole point is that your TA has read them. Papers cannot be accepted after the tutorial has taken place, and there is no late-penalty ladder here — it is in or it is not.

Marking. Pass/fail. Two points for each tutorial you attend *with* an accepted submission, to a maximum of six points across the three tutorials, which is this 10% component. Your TA can reject a submission that is too short, or that makes no genuine attempt to engage with the reading. That is the only quality bar.

[DECISION for Noah — default applied: pass/fail, two points per tutorial, max six. This mirrors Comparative A exactly. The alternative — grading them — is not survivable at n 500 with four TAs.]

The 80 cap. Departmental policy: this component is capped at 80. Full attendance with three accepted submissions earns a mark of 80 for the component, with reductions proportional to that. This reflects the realities of the Trinity marking scale, and it applies across the department, not just here.

[DECISION for Noah — default applied: the 80-cap applies, as it does in Comparative A. Confirm it is departmental policy for first-year modules too.]

The Assignment Submission Form. Discussion points are exempt. The School form is required for the blog post and the final essay, not for a one-page pass/fail submission.

[**DECISION for Noah — default applied: exempt. The syllabus currently implies the form is needed on every written submission; recommendation is to exempt these explicitly, which is what this handout does. Make the two agree.**]

Attendance

Attendance at tutorials is compulsory and it is half of this component. Submitting without attending earns nothing; attending without submitting earns nothing.

If you need an absence excused for certified medical reasons, your **College Tutor** must contact both your TA and me. Only requests from College Tutors are considered. If you want the credit for that tutorial, the discussion points must still be submitted — at or before the next tutorial, or within one week of the end of term if it was the last one. It is your job to make sure your College Tutor knows the procedure.

Tutorials are a place for open, warm and sometimes contentious discussion. People in the room have different backgrounds and different personal stakes in these questions. Engage seriously with the arguments and generously with the people making them.

Generative AI

Short version: don't. The full per-assessment table is in the [module outline](#), and for this component it says:

- **Brainstorming — not permitted.** The point of the exercise is that *you* had a reaction to the reading.
- **Research/learning assistance — permitted for one thing only:** clarifying a term or passage you could not follow after genuinely trying. Not for summarising the reading. Asking a model what an article says instead of reading it defeats the entire component, and your TA will be able to tell.
- **Writing assistance — not permitted.** These are one page and ungraded on style. Spellcheck is fine.
- **Direct AI content — not permitted.**

A rough, obviously human page is worth more here than a smooth one.

Dates

Tutorial	Date	Discussion points due
1 — orientation	[TBD]	—
2	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00
3	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00
4	[TBD]	[TBD], 20:00

Tutorial group allocation appears in your timetable. Dates and rooms are confirmed on Blackboard.